

Palm Zire 71

If the Palm Zire 21 is targeted at budget users, and the Palm Tungsten series is meant for the business class, then the Zire 71 is for the rest of us.

With a blue and silver combination, the PDA stands out from the pin-stripe crowd. Apart from the 320 x 320 colour screen, there's a five-way joystick and four application buttons on the front panel. The SD card slot, IR port power button, stereo jack and stylus access are on top. The speaker is placed on the metallic rear panel, while the Palm Universal Connector is, as usual, at the bottom. The handheld sits on its cradle via this connector—which can also be used to connect to other peripherals such as a modem and a keyboard—and talks to the PC via the USB port. The plastic stylus is very comfortable to use.

The Zire 71 is powered by the Texas Instruments OMAP310, a 144 MHz CPU and runs Palm OS 5.2.1. The handheld has 16 MB of internal memory, which is adequate for most, but we felt a little more would be welcome.

Pulling out the metallic rear panel reveals the 640 x 480 digital camera, and the screen becomes the viewfinder. Now you can use the dedicated shutter button (hidden on the top of the slider), or the joystick, to click pictures. Though there's no flash, you can adjust the resolution (160 x 120, 320 x 240, or 640 x 480) and save images in the RAM, or on the memory card. The desktop component of the Palm Photos application allows you to synchronise images between the handheld and the PC. We really missed Bluetooth support, though.

The handheld comes with a good selection of software—an SMS application, Audible Player for audio books, Kinoma Player for movies, RealOne Player for MP3s, Palm VersaMail, PowerOne Calculator for crunching tax returns and Adobe Acrobat Reader for Palm. If you have an IR-capable cell phone, and a subscription to the required services from your service provider, you can link the Zire 71 and the cellphone to access the Internet, send and receive e-mail, exchange SMS messages,

dial numbers from your PDA contacts list and even perform wireless HotSync operations.

The 144 MHz processor is fast enough for most applications and games. The handheld doesn't have a full-battery charge indicator. Also, the output from the headphone jack isn't decent enough. The screen, though, is exceptionally clear, uniformly lit and bright.

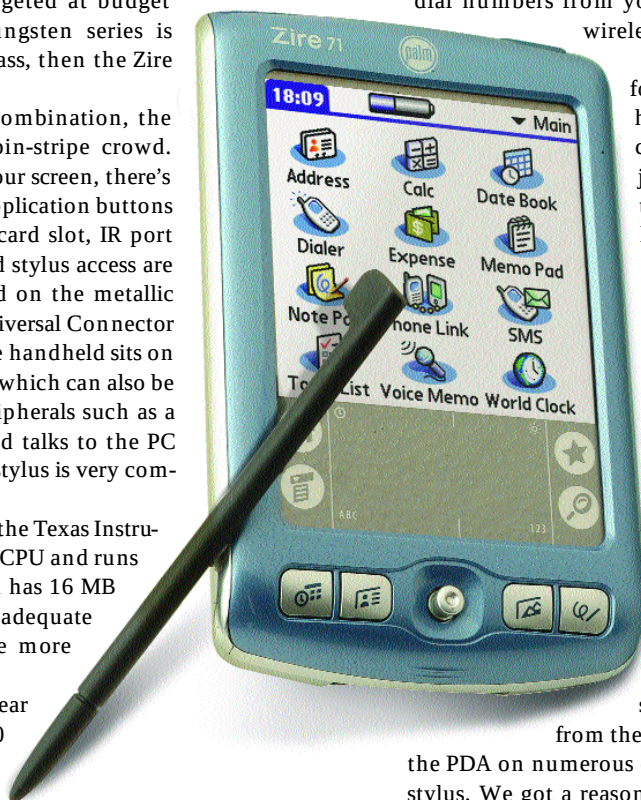
The button layout is a pleasure to work with. The five-way joystick lets you browse with one hand, and the slider camera operation can be accomplished single-handedly as well.

The images turned out better than those we took with cellphone cameras. However, since the shutter speed is a bit slow, you'll need to hold the PDA in place after clicking a picture, to avoid blurry images.

The mono speakers are badly placed—at the rear of the unit. As a result, alarms, game sounds and the like come out as faint squeaks. Similarly, the stylus could have been placed further away from the power button—we accidentally turned off

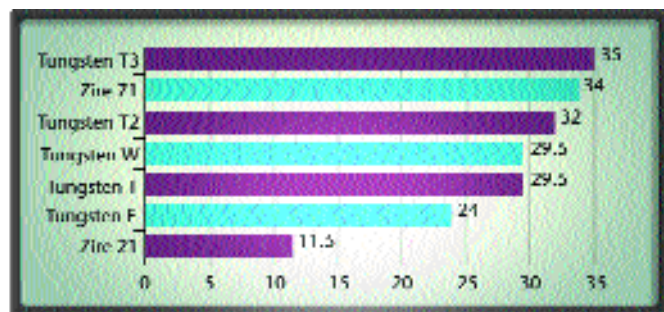
the PDA on numerous occasions while attempting to retrieve the stylus. We got a reasonable three hours and 14 minutes of continuous playtime using the Kinoma media player, with the battery fully charged.

With its funky looks, integrated camera and multimedia capabilities, the Zire 71 will appeal to the youth.



▲ The Zire 71's screen becomes the camera viewfinder when you open the slider

Bond's suave expression on the Die Another Day trailer



+ Integrated camera
- Few connectivity options
Price: Rs 19,999

Palm Zire 71

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Performance	▲▲▲▲▲
Features	▲▲▲▲▲
Ergonomics	▲▲▲▲▲
Value for money	▲▲▲▲▲